

Empire. Emperors, popes, and the Prussian kings awarded the family with titles and landed estates, and from then onward his family amassed fortunes. Albert, along with his mother and sister, still lives in the 500-room castle in Regensburg, Bavaria, that his family acquired in 1812.<sup>8</sup>

His father was Germany's richest aristocrat, Prince Johannes von Thurn und Taxis. The family goes back to twelfth-century Lombardy. He was the largest landowner in Germany. He owned a bank, breweries, metallurgical companies, 10 other palaces and castles, and extensive properties in Brazil, inherited from the Portuguese royal family.

The marriage of his father, Johannes, and his mother, Gloria, came to massive media attention during the late 1970s through mid-1980s. She was 20 and he was 53. They lived a wild, jet-set lifestyle. He was openly bisexual and frequented gay clubs. Princess Gloria wore "punk"-style clothes with brightly colored hairdos, earning her the nickname "Princess TNT." She famously barked like a dog on David Letterman's show.

The couple spent lavishly. One 210,000-square-foot palace contained 400 clocks—and 72,000 square feet of glass, which required weekly cleaning. They retained 70 liveried footmen. They had dozens of cars and limousines.

Overspending and bad investments took a toll on the family's great wealth. When Prince Johannes died in December 1990, following two unsuccessful heart transplants, he left debts totaling more than \$500 million. Just months before his death, the prince had fired his management consortium because of their poor performance.

His 30-year-old widow was left to sort out their complicated financial situation. For her part, she dramatically changed her lifestyle. She gave up most of her social life to spend time with her children and educate herself about her husband's financial affairs. She studied tax law, economics, and financial management with private tutors. She got to know the companies that the family owned so that she could make competent decisions.

She sold off a large portion of the family silver and jewelry, and two auctions in the early 1990s brought in about \$24 million. She sold the metallurgical companies and the bank. She trimmed the palace staff and gave up all but three of her cars. She donated family heirlooms and properties to the German government in exchange for a reduced tax bill.<sup>9</sup>